B1 Writing

Writing a short story

Tell a story about a past event with a clear order, past tenses and time words that link the events.

Stories are a common task in B1 exams and a great way to practise past tenses. A good short story has a clear beginning, a problem, and an ending, joined by time words.

Part	What to include	Useful language
Beginning	Who, where, when	*Last summer, I was staying with my cousin in Salalah.*
Problem	Something unexpected happens	*Suddenly, the car stopped in the middle of the road.*
Events	What people did, in order	*First we called for help. After that, we waited for an hour.*
Ending	How it finished and how people felt	*In the end, a farmer helped us. We were so relieved.*

Tenses

Tense	Use	Example
Past simple	The main events, one after another	*We left at six and arrived at noon.*
Past continuous	Background, or an action in progress when something happened	*It was raining when the bus broke down.*

Time words make a story easy to follow. *First, then, after that, suddenly, while, as soon as, in the end.* Add one feeling adjective at the end: *relieved, proud, embarrassed*.

Common mistake. Switching between present and past: *We went to the beach and suddenly my brother falls in the water.* Keep the whole story in the past: *fell*.

Practice

1. Put the verb in the past simple: We ___ (go) to the market early.
2. Choose the right tense: I (walked / was walking) home when I saw the accident.
3. Correct the mistake: Yesterday I miss the bus, so I take a taxi.
4. Add a time word: ___ we finished dinner, we went for a walk.
5. Order the parts: (a) In the end, we found the keys in my bag. (b) Last Friday, we were going to the airport. (c) Suddenly, I realised I didn't have the keys.

▼ **Show answers**

1. went
2. was walking
3. Yesterday I missed the bus, so I took a taxi.
4. After / As soon as
5. b, c, a